

CRUCIAL CONFRONTATIONS

Tools for Resolving Broken Promises,
Violated Expectations, and Bad Behavior

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The Big “So What”

How should you confront an employee who’s chronically late, a CFO who’s suspected of embezzling company funds, or a daughter who lies about her late nights with her “gangster boyfriend”? Failed promises, missed expectations and poor behaviors can create feelings of disappointment that compound into chronic problems for families, teams and organizations. **This book equips you with the skills to confront disappointing performance and behaviors, so you can solve problems, improve accountability, and strengthen relationships.**



Introduction

Crucial confrontations are face-to-face interactions that hold someone accountable, in a way that solve problems and strengthen relationships. Similar to crucial conversations—which the authors address in a previous book—crucial confrontations involve high stakes and strong emotions. However, **crucial conversations are about disagreements, while crucial confrontations are about disappointments, which arise when people don’t do what you believe they should be doing; these involve broken promises/rules, missed expectations or bad behaviors.**

Most people fear and avoid confrontation. They can’t find the words, try to change the subject, drop hints, or get harsh. Crucial confrontations cannot be handled through systems or policies; they can only be addressed by people, face-to-face. Fortunately, **such skills can be learned.**

KEY QUOTES

“Confrontations are the prickly, complicated, and often frightening performance discussions that keep you up nights.”

“To confront means to hold someone accountable, face to face.”

“Learn how to have crucial confrontations and you’ll never have to walk away from another conflict again.”

The authors studied more than 25,000 people across many institutions for 2 decades, shadowing opinion leaders and influencers for over 10,000 hours, to identify what made them effective. The authors found that **most organizations are losing 20-80% of their potential results due to their inadequacies in handling crucial confrontations**. By improving relevant skills, companies have seen improved accountability and morale, to improve productivity by as much as 40%, reduce costs by 50% and improve employee satisfaction by 20%.

In this summary, we'll outline the key principles and skills for handling crucial confrontations, in 3 parts: before, during and after a confrontation.



Before the Confrontation: Work on Me First

The success (or failure) of crucial confrontations depend on how and what we communicate. **Before entering a confrontation, we need to establish what we are confronting, if we wish to confront it, and to ensure we approach it with the right frame of mind.**

Identify "What" to Confront



Most crucial topics are actually a complex bundle of sub-issues. **A key challenge is to dissect the problem you're trying to address.** You know you're tackling the wrong issue if (a) you find yourself revisiting the same issue constantly, and (b) getting increasingly upset by it.

- Let's imagine you have a family friend, Mary, who has been working for you for 10 years, and regularly comes in late for work. Each time you discuss the issue, she'd improve for a day or two, then slip back to being late again. What's the *real* issue that you wish to confront? Is it about the principle of punctuality, the impact on her work, the example it's setting for other staff, her failure to keep her promises, or the feeling that she's exploiting your goodwill and friendship?
- If you confront someone without unbundling the problem, you'll probably end being rash and emotional, tackle the wrong issue (or try to tackle too many issues), and sound incoherent.

KEY QUOTES

"Policies, systems programs—any method for encouraging change—will never function fully until people know how to talk to one another about deviations and disappointments."

"Crucial confrontations live and die on the words people choose and the way people deliver them."

"If you can't reduce a violation to a clear sentence before you talk, the issue almost never becomes more understandable and focused as a conversation unfolds."

To decide what you want to confront, break it down in 3 parts:

▲ Use the “CPR approach” to consider which problem level to address:

- Content: Talk about something that just happened.
- Pattern: Talk about what has been happening over time.
- Relationship: Talk about what’s happening to your relationship, such as a loss of trust or respect.

🔍 Unbundle and expand the list of issues, by analyzing:

- The consequences of the problem to you, to the relationship, to the task(s), and other stakeholders.
- Your intentions and assumptions of the other person’s intentions. Remember that your suspicions have not been verified.

★ Prioritize what’s the most important, by asking what you want and don’t want for (a) yourself, (b) the other person and (c) the relationship.

Decide “If” you should Confront it



Once you’ve identified the core issue, you need to decide whether to confront it, or just let it go. Sometimes, there’s a clearly broken promise, e.g. a work deadline is missed, or your spouse promised but forgot an anniversary gift. At other times, the breach of expectations may be more ambiguous.

Generally, there are 4 signs that you should be speaking up:

🔥 When your negative feelings are showing despite your silence, e.g. you find yourself making snide remarks, feeling tensed and angry, dropping hints about the issue, etc.

😡 When your conscience is nagging at you, despite your best efforts to fit in or accept the situation.

KEY QUOTES

“Take the internal prodding as a sign that your silence isn’t warranted.”

✕ When you're trying very hard to justify your inaction, by playing down the consequences of staying silent, and exaggerating the dangers of speaking up.

🚩 When you're thinking that you're helpless and can't make a difference. Even if you currently lack the skills to effectively confront the problem, you can take action to improve your skills.

However, there are times when you may wish to hold back from speaking up, e.g. if your stand is clearly not supported by society, and/or you're unprepared. However, if you're committed to confront the issue—e.g. you decide to uphold or introduce a standard that no one else cares about—then:

★●● Differentiate yourself and give advanced warning of your expectations, so people have the chance to adjust; and

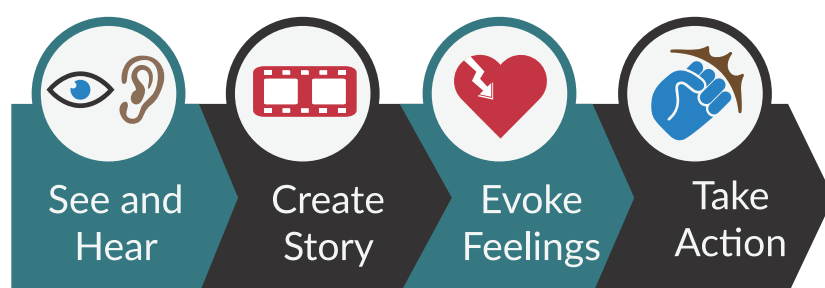
🚫 Establish your standards without being self-righteous.

Master Your Stories (Sort out your Headspace)



The first few seconds of a crucial confrontation can shape the tone of the conversation and outcome. We tend to assume the worst, then act in ways that confirm our assumptions. When someone breaks a promise, we often jump to conclusions and assume he/she is guilty. This sets the climate for the conversation before it even begins.

The **Path to Action** explains how our minds move rapidly from observation to action: We see/hear what others do, tell ourselves a story about why they do it, which triggers certain feelings and actions.



✕ Studies have shown that humans are prone to the **Fundamental Attribution Error**: we tend to attribute others' behaviors to internal factors like their personality/disposition

KEY QUOTES

"Don't confuse the question of whether the confrontation will be difficult with the question of whether you should deal with it."

"There are times when it's better not to bring up a problem or at least not to do so until you've done some preparatory work."

(e.g. “he’s lazy”, “she’s creative”), and neglect the influence of external situational factors.



Silence and violence. Most people react to disappointments by clamming up initially. Over time, the problem builds up, and the person eventually snaps and resorts to “violence”, in the form of threats, stares, insults, ultimatums etc. Once you switch from silence to violence, you compromise your professionalism and effectiveness, lose goodwill and credibility.



To stop the anger and hostility, you must view others as humans and not villains. Learn to tell the rest of the story.

- Ask a humanizing question like: “Why would a good, reasonable person do something like this?”
- Expand your view of the situation by using the six-cell model, to consider 6 sources of influence behind someone’s behavior:

LEVEL OF INFLUENCE	 MOTIVATION	 ABILITY
 SELF (the person involved)	1) Pain & Pleasure What are the person’s possible motives?	2) Strenghts & Weaknesses Does the person have the skills to do what’s required?
 OTHERS (including you)	3) Praise & Pressure What are the influences by peers, family, etc.?	4) Help & Hindrance How do others enabled or disabled this person?
 THINGS (reward,data tools etc.)	5) Carrots & Sticks What are the rewards or deterrents at play?	6) Bridges & Barriers What things can enable or disable this person?

Consider 3 levels of influence (*self, others, things*) and how they affect whether the person is *motivated* and *able* to take a certain action. This helps us to expand our range of possible stories, and replace our anger with curiosity.

1. *Pain & Pleasure*. What are the person’s possible motives? Is he/ she gaining certain pleasure or avoiding certain pain?
2. *Strengths & Weaknesses*. Does the person have the skills to do what’s required? Is this playing to his/her strength or weakness?
3. *Praise & Pressure*. What are the influences and pressures exerted by other people, e.g. colleagues, friends etc.?

KEY QUOTES

4. *Help & Hindrance*. How is this person enabled or disabled by others around him/her?
5. *Carrots & Sticks*. What are the financial rewards or risks, potential promotions or punishments at work?
6. *Bridges & Barriers*. How is this person's ability to deliver affected by technology, gadgets, data etc.?



During the Confrontation: Confront with Safety

Once you're clear on the issue that you wish to confront, and are looking at the other person objectively, you're ready to begin. *Start by describing the gap, focus on keeping it safe, and making it motivating and easy for the person to commit to being accountable.*

Describe the Gap



A gap, in the context of this book, refers to a major infraction, or the difference between what's expected and what actually happened. It's important to create a safe space for the conversation, before addressing the gap and trying to secure an agreement.



Start with Safety. When someone feels threatened, they move into silence or violence, and the conversation breaks down. *Maintain a safe space, and watch for signs that the person is feeling worried or fearful.* There are 2 core ingredients:

- *Mutual Purpose*: Your goal is to set a constructive mood and prevent misunderstandings. Start by stating your *intention*, focusing on what's important to both of you (not just you). To avoid misunderstanding, use "*contrasting*"—think of the worst assumption the other person may have, pre-empt it by stating that's not your intent, then explain what your true intent is.
- *Mutual Respect*: You need to sincerely respect the other party, and convey it through your tone of voice, facial expressions etc. Ask for *permission* before you address the sensitive issue, and always speak in *private* (rather than make it a public attack).

KEY QUOTES

"When we say gap, we mean... something that might be hard or even risky to discuss."

"If you can create safety, you can talk with almost anyone about almost anything— even about failed promises."

- Here's an example of a safe opening: [State mutual purpose & seek permission] "I'm concerned about the amount of time that all of us are spending in meetings. If you're ok, I'd like to share some ideas that could make our meetings more productive. [Add contrasting] I'm not unhappy with our team or with you. I enjoy working with you. I just want to explore ways for to make our meetings more productive. Can we talk about this?"



Address the Gap/Share your Path. Once the other party feels safe, we can move on to the gap.

- Start with facts to describe the gap as clearly and concisely as possible—what happened vs what was expected, e.g. "You promised to be home by 9pm, but you came back at 11pm". Focus on *what* was seen/heard rather than inferences on *why* it happened, e.g. "You shouted at Jay and called him a moron" is more factual than "You were trying to embarrass Jay."
- After establishing the facts, tentatively share your story, using tentative words like "I was wondering if...", rather than absolute words like "it was clear that..."
- End with a question like "Can we talk about this?" or "What happened?". Invite the other person to share, and be ready to listen sincerely with an open mind.

As the person explains, listen carefully for the 6 sources of influence, so you can identify the best course of action.

Motivate Others to Want to Take Action



You don't need charisma, power and perks to motivate someone; in fact, these are ineffective in the long-run. Instead, **motivation is all about consequences—human beings make decisions by anticipating the possible outcomes from our behaviors, then choosing the behavior that will deliver the best possible bundle of results.**



Make consequences visible. All behaviors come with natural consequences, e.g. if you don't manage your diabetes, you risk amputation. **Make the invisible visible, using 6 key methods:**

KEY QUOTES

"As a general rule, when you are sharing your path, it's best to start with the facts: what you saw and heard."

"Contrary to popular myth, you don't have to wield power or provoke fear to be an effective motivator."

"Motivation is about expectations, information, and communication."

	 Motivation	6 Ways to Motivate Action
 Self	Pain & Pleasure	• Link to existing values • Connect short-term benefits to long-term pain
 Others	Praise & Pressure	• Hold up a mirror • Introduce the hidden victims
 Things	Carrots & Sticks	• Focus on long-term benefits • Connect to existing carrots & sticks

- Link to existing values. Link the consequences to the person's core values, e.g. "If you don't take care of your diabetes, our children won't get to enjoy the time with their mum."
- Connect short-term benefits to long-term pain, e.g. "If you continue to smoke, it will affect your health and stamina, and you won't have a chance to be on the national team."
- Focus on long-term benefits, to shift the focus away from short-term challenges.
- Introduce the hidden victims, to show the unintended/unseen impact on others.
- Hold up a mirror, to show how the actions are seen by others.
- Connect to existing carrots & sticks. Link the results of fulfilling expectations with desired rewards.

 **Tailor your approach to the situation**, e.g. is the person simply unaware of the consequences, unmotivated by them, or resistant to what must be done?

- It's not always easy to diagnose the underlying reasons for the gaps. The situation may be ambiguous, complicated, or people may hide their true reasons (e.g. refuse to admit that they don't know something). You may also have differing priorities, or the person genuinely may not want to do what you're asking. Joint exploration improves the chances of identifying the cause(s), and it takes patience and skill to identify what would motivate others.

KEY QUOTES

"Change others' view of the consequence bundle and their behavior will follow."

"Change people's hearts by changing their minds."

"Desiring to get out of hard and noxious work doesn't reflect a character flaw; it's what smart people do."

"The goal of exploring consequences is to bring to the surface the issues that make the task undesirable."

- If you've tried all the options above, and the other party still continues to violate the agreement, discipline may be required. In such cases, you need to know the mechanics and processes in your organization, partner with others in authority (e.g. partner your boss to discipline a staff, or partner your spouse to discipline your child), explain what would happen if the infraction continues, be consistent and follow through.
- Sometimes, full resolution is impossible, e.g. your boss may apologize for using abusive language but cannot promise that he will be able to rein in his temper in future. In such cases, you can't impose your will on others. However, you can share your coping strategy to distance yourself from the problem, e.g. let your boss know that if he loses his temper again, you may politely excuse yourself until he cools down.



To stay in dialogue, here are some points to watch for:

- Don't let sharing sound like threatening;
- Be open to others' perspectives of natural consequences;
- Don't oversell: stop once the person understands the overall impact and agrees on what needs to be done.



Finish well. After completing the steps above—discussing consequences, making it motivating, and getting consent to honour your agreement—you must wrap up the confrontation with a follow-up plan (which we'll elaborate on later).

Make it Easy to Keep Commitments



After you've identified the barriers, you need to remove them. People naturally avoid hard or unpleasant work—it's **your job as a leader to make things easier and more desirable**. In the short run, you can apply pressure to get someone to do something they don't wish to do. However, in the long run, you need to remove the real or perceived barriers that make the job undesirable.



Avoid jumping in quickly with suggestions and advice. Instead, **involve others in the problem-solution**, so you motivate and enable them.

KEY QUOTES

"There's a fine line between sharing natural consequences and threatening others... If your motives are wrong, sharing becomes threatening."

"It's your job to help remove the barrier. It's your job to help make it easy."

- Start by asking people for their ideas—they may already know the answers, or simply need some advice on where to start. By jointly working on the barriers with them, you empower them and give them greater ownership of the solutions.
- Return to the Six-Cell Model to brainstorm existing and potential ability barriers for the self, others and things. Ask these 3 questions: Will this person keep facing the problem? Will others have similar problems? Have we identified all of the root causes? Pretend to be an ignorant outsider and ask questions like, “Why can’t we do this?”, “If you ran this place, how would you solve the problem?”. Give people access to the information they need to make the right decisions.

	 Ability	“Brainstorm Ability Barriers”
 Self	Strengths & Weaknesses	• Will this person keep facing the problem?
 Others	Helps & Hindrances	• Will others have similar problems? • Have we identified all of the root causes?
 Things	Bridges & Barriers	

 End off by confirming if the person is willing and able to do what’s required. Pop a verifying question to check that all key motivation and ability issues have been addressed. If you’ve tackled ability issues, check for motivation issues, e.g. “If I can get this sorted by 1pm, are you willing to do what’s required to finish it by 5pm?” Or, if you’ve tackled motivation issues, check for ability issues, e.g., “It sounds like you’re willing to do this. Is there anything else that could stand in your way?”

Stay Focused and Flexible



Even if you’ve considered your “what” and “if” carefully, you may find new issues and problems emerging as the conversation unfolds.

 **Be flexible:** Acknowledge the new issue and consider what’s the right problem to address—the original problem, the new one, or both.

KEY QUOTES

“Jumping in with your answers isn’t always the smart move.”

“When facing ability barriers, make impossible tasks possible and nasty tasks less nasty.”

“Think hidden forces, think lots of forces, and keep at it until you’re satisfied that you’ve wrestled every single barrier to the ground.”



Be focused: Deal with one problem at a time. If you decide to tackle both issues, pause to resolve the new problem before returning to the original one. We'll explain how below.

Here are **4 emergent problems** that you're likely to face, and how you can handle them:



Loss of safety. When people feel unsafe, they move into silence or violence. In such cases, you must step out, create safety (by pointing to shared purpose, reinforcing your intent, using contrasting to clarify misunderstanding, and apologizing if needed), then step back into the conversation.



Out-of-control emotions. If the other person becomes extremely emotional (e.g. starts throwing things or becomes abusive), stepping out of the conversation may be insufficient. First, *ensure your safety*—leave the situation if you may be unsafe. If you're not in danger, move on to *dissipate the emotion*, by exploring the person's path to action, then addressing what emerges. Use the *AMPP approach* to enhance your listening skills: Ask what's going on, Mirror the person to encourage dialogue, Paraphrase for understanding, and Prime by adding words to the conversation (e.g. "are you upset because...").



A new/different issue becomes a problem. Sometimes, a new and more serious infraction may occur during your conversation, e.g. you're discussing how your daughter has broken her curfew, when you realize she is lying to you. If you choose to switch topics, place a *bookmark* on the current topic and clarify the switch by saying, "I'd like to talk about what just happened". Move on to address the new topic, before returning to the original bookmarked topic. After resolving the new issue, assess if it's still safe to return to the previous topic, or take a break and continue another time.



Loss of trust. It's common for people to justify a broken promise by saying "something came up", and shift the conversation to discuss that distraction, instead of the failed promise and loss of trust. To maintain accountability while giving flexibility, use this simple statement, "If something comes up, let me know as soon as you can."

KEY QUOTES

"On-the-spot creativity calls for an enormous amount of flexibility."

"We become righteously indignant only when others have tread on sacred ground."

"It's okay to change topics, but always clarify what you're doing. Place a bookmark where you just were so that it will be easy to return to it later."



After the Confrontation: Move to Action

By now, we have an agreement, and can follow up with a specific plan, using **WWWF—Who does What, by When, and Follow up:**



Who: Ensure there's someone accountable for the whole task, as well as each sub-task.



What: Define the specific behaviors expected and ask if anything is unclear. Contrast the dos and don'ts to be specific, e.g. "Write down your proposed solutions on 1 page and present them. Don't come empty-handed."



By **When:** include quantifiable numbers and times e.g. Wednesday 6pm.



Follow up: Clarify when and how you'll follow up. Avoid micro-management (i.e. following up too closely) and abandonment (i.e. being too hands-off). To determine the ideal level of follow up, consider the level of risk (or criticality of the task), trust and competence of the party involved.

- Check-up vs check-back. Use check-ups if you feel uneasy about the task, e.g. set a date and time to jointly review the progress. Use check-backs for more routine tasks where the person is competent and trusted, e.g. set a date and time for the person to check back with updates.
- Summarize the key outcomes. State the specific agreement, and end with a question so the other party can confirm the agreement, e.g. "Is that right?", "Can you see anything else that we haven't discussed which may cause a problem?"
- Follow up. You should take the lead in ensuring there's proper follow-up, so you can identify what worked or didn't, and provide support to narrow or remove future gaps.

KEY QUOTES

"If you care about gaining genuine commitment, give the other person the opportunity to say yes to a very specific agreement."

"Allowing failure eventually destroys results and relationships."



Conclusion & Other Details to Look Out For

Here's a recap of the Crucial Confrontations framework.



KEY QUOTES

The book ends with an extended example to show how a husband applies these principles to address his concerns of his wife's possible infidelity. The book also includes other resources including:

- 12 complex situations (e.g. confronting an authoritarian boss or someone "fragile") and how you should deal with them;
- A self-assessment survey to understand how you typically handle crucial confrontations;
- Additional diagnostic questions for the 6 sources of influence;
- Tips for motivating with praise; and
- Questions for group discussions.

You can download some of these resources at the [official website](#).